Shoot Me First

By Carol A. Taber

INTRODUCTION

On October 2, 2006 Charles Carl Roberts entered Georgetown School, a one-room Amish school house in Lancaster County, Pennsylvania and began addressing the pupils, showing them an automatic handgun. In the classroom were 15 male pupils, 10-12 female pupils, one teacher and a number of assistants - older children and adults. He told the boys to leave, along with a pregnant woman and three others with infants. The gunman made the girls line up in front of the blackboard, where he tied their feet using wire or plastic cuffs. He then barricaded the doors with large pieces of wood he had brought with him. The next minutes must have been horrific for the girls as each awaited what was clearly to be their execution day. In the midst of the terror, however came quite voices . . . Shoot Me First by Carol A. Taber.

We know there is great courage and honor among our military, but many Americans doubt that such splendid traits are in sight anymore among average American citizens. There has been such a rampaging coarsening of American culture and society - delivered to us through a

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constant stream of lowest-common-denominator, omnipresent media - that one wonders how we can further degrade ourselves from Janet Jackson's "costume malfunction", staged for every American kid to witness in the crassly and grossly over-commercialized Super Bowl.

But there are still laudable and honorable traits living in these United States, and great depth of character. I know because I saw them, and read about them, over these past few days.

Even in the face of such evil fury as we witnessed in Amish country, there was dignity, valor and calm, facing death. In 13-year-old Marian Fisher, the oldest of the five Amish girls who were slaughtered in their simple, one room schoolhouse, West Nickel Mines, we know this. Marian stepped forward and said to her murderer, "Shoot me first". Marian's younger sister, Barbie, then asked Charles Carl Roberts IV to shoot her

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second. Barbie, among the ten girls who were shot, survived, while Marian did not.

This is the sort of thing for whom our country normally awards such honors as the Congressional Medal of Honor for valor under the frenzy of battle. This is why so many of the Honors are awarded posthumously. Were these gestures any different?

There is still respect in this country, seen in the throngs of people who removed their hats and stood in silence as the funeral processions passed by. Not a word was spoken while the black carriages passed with the solemn mourners inside. This plain black procession of nineteenth-century horse-drawn carriages with simple folk inside was nothing short of a majestic sight for our wearied eyes, already wearied of the hi tech, edgy gloss of our very young twenty-first century.

There is still dignity and kindness among us, evident in the no-fly zones established overhead the funerals,

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cordoned off to allow the Amish to grieve in private, without the world gawking at their misfortune. To my knowledge, no out-of-control yahoos violated that zone as would be expected under almost any other sort of similar condition.

There were magnanimous and gallant offers made, too, that saved further agony for the Pennsylvania Amish. Mike Gallagher turned over his entire radio show to the immensely strange people from the ultra left wing group who picket funerals (I choose not to identify their group and give them the coverage they crave). He allowed this so that they wouldn't be heard and seen by the worldwide media in their picketing of the funerals of those angelic little kids, executed gangland style. This group had planned to proclaim that the girls deserved their unspeakably cruel deaths.

There was compassion, seen in the silent candlelight vigils held for the families of those defenseless girls slain by a madman. No riots, no speeches, no t-shirt

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selling, no proselytizing…just sorrow and sympathy bearing witness to a deep and abiding tragedy in a farm community of innocents.

There was forgiveness, witnessed in the two families – those of the murderer and those of the murdered – recognizing each other's terrific loss. The Amish folk have invited the murderer's family to their homes so that they can share their grief together. In fact, many of the Amish have offered forgiveness for the shooter whom some would more easily call the Devil himself. I admit I do.

And so I sit back and contemplate what I have seen. There are many times when I grieve for the loss of the America I knew when I was young. I do not see that wonderful place in our current culture, only among some families who steadfastly adhere to the principles upon which they were raised. But these valiant families exist in a maelstrom of political correctness gone wild, amidst high school graduates who can't read, among sheer

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vulgarity blasted into our living rooms daily, and within a depraved sense of what is right and what is wrong that matches nothing we have known before. With this backdrop, it is tough to imagine America's future resembling anything of what it was meant to be at its founding. With such polar opposite thinking in our country, it remains to be seen which vision will prevail.

In the meantime, there are those of us who can take comfort in the sights and sounds of the Amish country, and in particular, in their response to the evil that went to school that day. This is a spot in our country where valor, dignity, manners, compassion and courage know no bounds, and we are reminded of life as it once was…and let's hope might still be.

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